

The most brilliant comet ever seen – the Great September Comet of 1882 – was brighter than a full moon.

Space companies are planning to mine asteroids – some contain valuable metals, such as platinum, which could be worth over a trillion dollars.

The biggest crater on Earth, the Vredefort Crater in South Africa, is 300 km (185 miles) across. It was blasted out by an asteroid impact 2 billion years ago.

The difference between a star and a planet when you look into the night sky? Stars are huge nuclear reactors, churning energy into space. Planets are inert, and simply reflect starlight.

Our Milky Way galaxy and the nearby Andromeda Galaxy are approaching each other (unlike most galaxies, which are moving away). In five billion years' time, they will collide, to create a vast galaxy nicknamed Milkomeda.

Life on our planet formed from substances rich in carbon possibly delivered to our planet by comets hitting Earth.

When you see the light from a distant star, it may no longer exist – because its light may have taken thousands of years to reach us.

There are almost a trillion trillion stars in all the galaxies in the Universe. That means there are more stars than there are grains of sand on Earth.

One theory suggests that the Universe may end in a Big Rip: planets will be torn away from stars, then planets themselves ripped apart, and finally all the atoms will explode.

Primitive life, in the form of bugs and bacteria, could exist in many moons in the Solar System. Titan, orbiting Saturn, has seas of ethane and methane: raw materials of life. Jupiter's Europa has an ocean under its icy surface, perhaps teeming with life.

On a clear, moonless night, you can see up to 3,000 stars with the naked eye.

The gravity on the Moon's surface is just 17 per cent that of Earth's. If you jump 1 m (3 ft) high on Earth, you would be able to jump 6 m (19 ft) on the Moon.

Astronauts are up to 5 cm (2 in) taller in space because their spines expand in the weightlessness.

If you counted the stars of the Milky Way at a rate of one a second, it would take you about 5,000 years to count them all.

Yuri Gagarin's mother first found out about his flight into space when news of the mission broke.

Space rockets need to reach a speed of 40,000 kph (25,000 mph) to escape the gravitational pull of Earth. This is called the escape velocity.

Astronauts on the International Space Station have been growing plants in space. The techniques they have developed will be needed on any future mission to Mars, as astronauts will need to grow their own food.